



CZECH REPUBLIC

The General Debate of the 80th United Nations General Assembly Session

Statement by
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As delivered

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Madame President, Excellencies, ladies and gentlemen,

I am humbled to speak here in front of you again. Today, I wish to address two main issues: UN's achievements and necessity of its reform and prospect of multilateralism in the light Russian aggression.

Eighty years ago, the United Nations was founded with great hope to prevent war and destruction – never to repeat the horrors of World War II.

My country proudly stood amongst the founding nations, signing the Charter that would become our collective moral compass.

Since 1945, we have witnessed remarkable achievements. The United Nations helped to prevent another full-scale world conflict.

It assisted the dissolution of colonialism and rise of new sovereign countries in Asia, Africa, Europe and Latin America.

Together, we created a robust multilateral system of rules and global cooperation in international security, human rights and economic development.

Together with the UN we have fought famine, disease, illiteracy and poverty in some of the world's most vulnerable regions. Dozens of peacekeeping missions have helped to ease tensions in conflict zones.

Thanks to its long-standing efforts, the UN has helped transform countless lives and laid the groundwork for a better world. A world which is more humane and more cooperative.

It provided a platform where even the smallest nations can speak out and be heard.

The UN remains the only institution where the world can collectively confront global crises.

Not with weapons, but with dialogue, shared responsibility and pressure where necessary. UN's greatest achievement is not perfection, but its persistence.

With many devastating conflicts ongoing, Russia's invasion of Ukraine has significantly transformed the global security landscape.

Since the last General Debate a year ago, our world has not become more secure. On the contrary.

In the game of smoke and mirrors, Russia continues targeting civilians, civilian infrastructure, foreign diplomatic missions and most recently, even our neighbouring country, Poland.

Not to forget the acts of hybrid warfare on our own territory.

These range from disinformation campaigns and attempts to undermine public trust to cyber-attacks – and even acts of sabotage carried out by mercenaries recruited online.

Despite being the largest country on the map, Russia still aims to seize Ukrainian territory and expand its sphere of influence.

Backed by China, Iran, North Korea and other countries that help it circumvent sanctions and provide economic or political support.

Russia, a permanent member of the UN Security Council, not only violates the principles of state sovereignty and territorial integrity enshrined in the UN Charter but also sets a dangerous example and precedent that aggression can yield territorial and political gain.

Ladies and gentlemen,

Our multilateral system was created on the premise that rules apply to all without exception.

The consequences of this war go far beyond the news headlines. This war threatens to dismantle our system of governance based on mutual respect, equal partnership and rules we all subscribed to.

What is happening in Europe today could happen anywhere else tomorrow - under different circumstances, but under the exact same pretext. If Russia wins this unjust war, it will legitimise the triumph of brute force. Turning a blind eye to Ukraine today is a green light to any future aggressor, anywhere in the world.

Disruptions of the status quo in the Taiwan Strait or elsewhere in the Indo-Pacific would further destabilize global security and trade. Geographical distance offers no protection – security in one part of the world is directly linked to security everywhere.

Tolerating the principle of might makes right will lead to the end of multilateralism and the beginning of life under principles dictated by a powerful few.

It would be a future with history deliberately rewritten, with lies promoted as facts and with truth slowly disappearing from our discourse and memory – just the opposite of what most of our nations fought for in the previous century.

The heroism of Ukrainian people, their willingness to sacrifice for freedom, and global solidarity with Ukraine, demonstrate that most of us still believe in universal values - and in our responsibility to defend them.

To achieve sustainable peace, we, democratic allies from all over the world, must act in unity and intensify our economic pressure on Russia. This is the only way to bring the aggressor to the negotiating table.

Such peace - based on the existing international law, including territorial integrity and the right for self-determination - is in the interest of not only European countries, but of the whole international community.

Any future peace agreement must send a clear message worldwide that aggressor cannot be rewarded and borders cannot be changed by force!

Ladies and gentlemen,

the structure of the UN was based on the outcome of the World War II.

Today, one of the UN Security Council Permanent Members – Russia – is waging a ruthless war while obstructing any constructive solutions put forward.

It is in light of these new geopolitical realities that we need a strong and effective UN system capable of responding to today's global challenges — from security threats and climate change to the rapid evolution of new technologies.

Otherwise, we risk sliding into a world that is more fragmented and far less predictable.

Czechia welcomes the UN 80 Initiative and the commitments in the Pact for Future. Yet these ambitions stand in stark contrast with today's reality. In the light of Russian aggression against Ukraine, the UN Security Council is currently failing its purpose and mission.

Therefore, we advocate for a comprehensive reform of the UN Security Council for greater effectiveness, inclusiveness, transparency and accountability with the aim to honour the principles of UN Charter and strengthen the voice of underrepresented regions.

Freedom and human rights are not granted entitlements. They are hard-won principles that must be cherished and protected.

Security Council membership should not be seen as a matter of prestige or privilege, but above all responsibility to defend global peace.

That's why Czechia is seeking a non-permanent seat on the UN Security Council for the term 2032 - 2033 with a clear commitment: to uphold the rules-based international order.

We cannot afford to have the UN paralysed and blocked in its ability to respond to crises and challenges.

Current urgent crises are already consuming too much of our attention and resources at the expense of other major, equally pressing issues.

Madam President, ladies and gentlemen,

As I mentioned at the beginning of my speech, the UN significantly improved the quality of life of billions, including through access to education, healthcare and services.

In this year's Sustainable development report, Czechia ranked 10th out of 167 countries. I am fortunate to be a citizen of a country which, by global standards offers a secure and comfortable life.

This does not mean there are no challenges. Much work still lies ahead if we are to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals 2030 – both at home and globally.

After all, most of the challenges we are facing are global. No single nation is powerful enough to succeed alone.

That's why we need more dialogue.

That's why we need greater cooperation and collective action.

And ultimately, that's why multilateralism must not only survive – it must thrive.

Not only for us, but most importantly for future generations. Thank you.